TEXT TYPE · B2 · USUALLY THE SHORT TASK

The e-mail

Clear purpose, proper format

Word count	Register	Subject line	Sign-off
~250 words (225–275)	**Usually formal**	**Required**	**Yours faithfully / sincerely**

STRUCTURE AND LAYOUT

To: – [recipient's e-mail]
From: – [your e-mail]
Date: – [date]
Subject: – [clear and descriptive]
Dear Sir or Madam, / Dear Mr/Ms [Name],
Introduction – state why you are writing in the first sentence
Body paragraphs 1–3 – one content point per paragraph
Conclusion – restate purpose, expected response
Yours faithfully, / Yours sincerely, – faithfully = name unknown; sincerely = name known

DO'S AND DON'TS

DO

- Include all header elements (To, From, Date, Subject)
- State your reason for writing in the first sentence
- Use formal language – no slang
- Use full forms (do not instead of don't)
- Leave a blank line between paragraphs
- Match greeting to closing (Dear Sir → Yours faithfully)
- Use "softer" phrases when criticising: I would like to point out, it seems to me

DON'T

- No contractions in formal e-mails
- No emojis or emoticons
- No casual greetings (Hey, Hi there)
- Don't use an unprofessional e-mail address
- Don't forget a subject line
- Don't mix up faithfully/sincerely

WEAKER VS. STRONGER

WEAKER

Hi! Your headphones broke after two days and I want my money back, thanks.

STRONGER

Dear Sir or Madam, I am writing to request a refund for the headphones I bought on 3 May, which stopped working after two days.

Why it matters. A formal e-mail names its purpose in the first line and keeps a polite, formal register throughout. The casual version would be marked down for register and tone.

KEY TIP

Faithfully vs. sincerely: "Dear Sir/Madam" (name unknown) → Yours faithfully. "Dear Mr/Ms Brown" (name known) → Yours sincerely. This mistake is easy to spot. If the task is an informal e-mail (to a friend, a host family, an exchange partner), the same rules apply the other way round: "Hi Anna," / "Dear Tom,", contractions are fine, and you close with "Best wishes" or "Take care". Read the task: the recipient decides the register.

MODEL TEXT

Complaint regarding Summer Language Course in Brighton (~250 words · Formal register)

> **The task.** You recently attended a two-week summer language course in Brighton that did not match the advertisement. Write an e-mail of complaint to the language school.
>
> In your e-mail you should:
>
> - describe the problems with the classes
> - complain about the afternoon programme
> - explain how the staff reacted when you raised the problems
>
> Write around 250 words. The model follows the five-paragraph plan: introduction, one paragraph for each content point, conclusion.

Structure Language Text-specific

`To: info@globalenglish.example`
`From: sarah.berger@email.example`
`Date: 10 April 2026`
`Subject: Complaint regarding Summer Language Course in Brighton`[1]

Dear Sir or Madam,[2]

I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with[3] the two-week language course I attended at your Brighton school from 16 to 27 March 2026. Although[4] your website promised small class sizes and experienced teachers, my experience was far from what had been advertised[5].

To begin with,[6] the classes themselves were a serious problem: with up to 22 students in a group, individual attention was impossible. Furthermore,[7] our teacher changed three times during the course, and the final replacement had no formal teaching qualification. As a result,[8] several students felt they had not improved at all.

On top of this, the afternoon programme was very disappointing.[9] The brochure promised daily excursions and sports activities, but two of the trips were cancelled without notice, and on several afternoons we were simply left in an empty classroom with a film.

When I raised these problems with the reception staff,[10] I was simply told that nothing could be done, and none of the staff seemed willing to take responsibility. To make matters worse, the written complaint I handed in during the course was never answered.

I would therefore like to request[11] a partial refund of the course fees, as the services provided did not match the description on your website. I look forward to hearing from you within 14 days.[12] Should I not receive a satisfactory response[13], I will have no choice but to share my experience on public review platforms.

Yours faithfully,[14]
Sarah Berger

WHAT THE EXAMINER NOTICES IN THIS MODEL

The numbers match the marked passages in the model text.

1. **Header – all 4 elements required**: *"To: info@globalenglish.example From: sarah.berger@email.example Date: 10 April 2026 Subject: Complaint regardi..."*
2. **Formal greeting (name unknown)**: *"Dear Sir or Madam,"*
3. **Set phrase – complaint opener**: *"I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with"*
4. **Concession – B2 linking**: *"Although"*
5. **Formal understatement – effective in complaints**: *"far from what had been advertised"*
6. **Content point 1 – problems with the classes**: *"To begin with,"*
7. **B2 linking word**: *"Furthermore,"*

8. **Linking word (cause and effect)**: *"As a result,"*
9. **Content point 2 – a new complaint, a new paragraph**: *"On top of this, the afternoon programme was very disappointing."*
10. **Content point 3 – how the staff reacted**: *"When I raised these problems with the reception staff,"*
11. **Clear, specific demand**: *"I would therefore like to request"*
12. **Sets a deadline – professional and firm**: *"I look forward to hearing from you within 14 days."*
13. **Formal conditional – firm but polite**: *"Should I not receive a satisfactory response"*
14. **Correct sign-off (Dear Sir → faithfully)**: *"Yours faithfully,"*

USEFUL PHRASES

Complaint openers

- I am writing to express my dissatisfaction with...
- I am writing to complain about...
- I would like to draw your attention to...
- I was appalled to find...

Application openers

- I am writing to apply for the position of... as advertised in...
- I am writing with reference to your advertisement...
- I believe I am suitable for the position as I...

Letter to the editor openers

- I am writing in response to the article on..., which appeared in... on [date].
- I have just read your article on... and I feel I must respond.
- You raised some issues which I feel strongly about.

Closings (all sub-types)

- I look forward to hearing from you at your earliest convenience.
- I look forward to receiving the information requested.
- I am available for an interview at your convenience.
- Thank you for your cooperation in correcting this matter.

THE FOUR SUB-TYPES

Letter / E-mail of Complaint

You are unhappy with a product, service, or experience and you want something done about it. Stay firm but professional, never aggressive.

Use the standard e-mail header (To/From/Date/Subject). State your reason in the first sentence. Describe problems clearly in the body. End with a specific, reasonable demand.

Tip. A complaint shows whether you can be firm without being rude. "I am writing to express my dissatisfaction" works much better than "Your service was awful." Examiners look for a calm, professional tone.

Letter / E-mail of Application

You are applying for a job, internship, volunteer position, or course. Be specific and confident, and show the employer why you are the right person.

Standard e-mail header. First paragraph: what you're applying for and where you saw it. Middle: your qualifications and relevant experience. Final paragraph: express enthusiasm and availability for interview.

Tip. Tense tip: use present simple for current skills ("I am a reliable person"), past simple for past experience ("I worked for..."), present perfect continuous for ongoing activities ("I have been studying..."). Mixing these correctly shows B2 grammar range.

Letter to the Editor

You respond to an article or comment published in a newspaper or magazine. You must reference the original publication, then agree or disagree with the arguments made. It is a classic exam task.

Standard e-mail header (To: editor@publication.example). Greeting: "Dear Sir or Madam," or "Dear Editor,". The first sentence must name the article, the publication and the date. Sign off with Yours faithfully + full name + town/city.

Tip. Make it personal and local: explain why you care about this issue and how it affects your community.

E-mail of Enquiry / Requesting Information

You want information about something – a product, a service, a course, an event, or a programme. You must be specific about what information you need.

Standard e-mail header. State your purpose in the first sentence. Use indirect questions ("I would like to know whether..." rather than "Is there...?") for a more formal tone. Each paragraph covers one information request.

Tip. Indirect questions ("I would like to know whether...") are more formal than direct questions ("Is there...?"). Using them throughout shows good control of formal register and grammar.

More online. On the website this text type also has a second model text (“Complaint about a faulty online order”, ~250 words · formal) and a realistic borderline text with notes on where it loses marks: matura.bernhardgmeiner.com/email/